

The treasure for all

Hidden treasure story • 3-4 years old



Pip the hedgehog finds a soft, crinkly map under a shiny leaf. The map smells like pine and apples. A tiny red X sits by the brook. Next to the X is a little stone tower. "A cairn," whispers Pip. "A treasure," he whispers again. His nose wiggles. His heart feels bouncy and brave.

Pip shows the map to his friends. Tulla the turtle blinks slowly. Nib the mouse twitches her whiskers. Flip the squirrel flips his tail. "Let's go together," says Pip. "We all help," says Tulla. "We take turns," says Nib. "We listen," says Flip. They smile. They are small and big, quick and slow. That is good. That is kind.

They walk through the meadow. Dew kisses their feet. Bees hum soft songs. Clovers smell sweet and green. The sun feels warm like a blanket. The brook laughs and splashes over stones. "This way," says Pip. He feels a little flutter in his tummy. He takes a deep breath. "Brave breath," he says. His friends nod. They are close. They feel safe together.

They meet a muddy patch. The mud goes squish, squish. "I can find dry spots," says Tulla. She taps stones with her strong shell. Tap, tap. Step, step. They cross. They meet a tangle of tall grass. "I can make a path," says Nib. Snip, snip with tiny teeth. A soft green tunnel opens. They meet a fallen log. "I can climb and look," says Flip. He climbs and waves. "Clear on top!" They go under and over. They laugh. They help. They say, "Thank you."

The brook gets louder. Shhh, shhh, hush, hush. The water smells fresh and cool. There, by the water, stands the cairn. It is a neat pile of round, smooth stones. The stones are gray, brown, and white. They shine in the sun. Pip touches one. It is cool and silky. "The treasure is under," he says. "We must not hurt it," says Tulla. "We go slow," says Nib. "I will watch and guide," says Flip.

They make a plan. Tulla is steady. Pip is gentle. Nib is quick. Flip sees from a branch. "Left one," he says. Pip lifts one stone with careful paws. He puts it on soft moss. "Right one," says Flip. Tulla slides it down. No cracks, no drops. "Small one," says Nib. She wiggles it free. The stones go clink, clink, very quiet. They sing a little rhyme. "Slow and kind. Calm and kind." They breathe. They smile.

Under the last smooth stone is a tiny wooden box. It smells like cinnamon and rain. There is a soft ribbon of grass around it. Pip brushes sand away with a leaf. He opens the lid. The box holds bright seeds, a shell that hums like the sea, a blue glass bead that makes rainbow dots, and a little note in berry ink. Nib reads, "For all friends. Share."

Pip's eyes shine. "For everyone," he says. "Yes," says Tulla. "Yes," says Nib. "Yes!" says Flip. They put the cairn back, stone by stone. It stands again, neat and proud.

They plant the seeds by the brook. The soil is crumbly and sweet. Pat, pat, pat. They hang the shell and the bead on a low branch. The wind plays. Tinkle, hush, tinkle. Colors dance on the water. Soon, friends arrive. A shy mole peeks out. A bright robin sings. A big toad smiles. "Come share," says Pip. "All friends," says Tulla. "All welcome," says Nib. "Different is good," says Flip. They sit together. They listen to the soft shell song. They watch rainbow dots on furry noses and little paws.

The sun slides low and gold. The air feels like warm tea. Pip leans on Tulla's shell. Nib curls in his lap. Flip's tail makes a soft fan. Pip's heart feels full and calm. "We were brave," he says. "We were gentle," says Tulla. "We were smart," says Nib. "We shared," says Flip.

The brook whispers good-night. The cairn stands tall and kind. The seeds sleep under the soil. The treasure is for all. Pip closes his eyes. He smiles. "Together," he whispers. And the meadow smiles back.

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) What does Pip find under a shiny leaf?

- A shiny rock
- A soft map
- A big flower
- A tasty snack

2) What do Pip and his friends want to find?

- A treasure
- A new home
- A big party
- A warm blanket

3) What do they find under the last stone?

- A shiny coin
- A wooden box
- A soft toy
- A magic wand

4) What do they do with the seeds they find?

- They eat them
- They plant them
- They throw them away
- They hide them

Correct answers:

1) A soft map 2) A treasure 3) A wooden box 4) They plant them

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Crinkly: Having many small folds or wrinkles; not smooth.

Cairn: A pile of stones that is used as a marker or a memorial.

Flutter: To move lightly and quickly, like a bird's wings.

Steady: Firm, stable, or not moving; calm and consistent.

Crumbly: Breaking easily into small pieces; not solid or hard.

Hum: To make a low, continuous sound like a bee or a tune.

Shiny: Reflecting light; bright and smooth.